

Session 1: Turning Your Talents into Income

There are 5 steps to turning your talent into income:

1. Identify your talents.
2. Identify opportunities in the world.
3. Connect your gifts to the opportunities.
4. Develop your talent into a strength.
5. Focus your strength in large, uninterrupted blocks of time to create massive value for others.

Technology changes the game for all of us. Specifically, the accelerating pace and efficiency of technology has created the following "game changers."

1. Technology automates manual work and eliminates many manual labor jobs.
2. Technology changes the location of the person who still does the manual work. Now, this person will be the person who can do the best job for the lowest price, regardless of where they are in the world.
3. Technology puts cutting edge knowledge in the hands of anyone who has a computer.
4. Technology puts the power of marketing and selling into the hands of anyone who has a computer. In the old days, if you wanted to publish you'd have to buy a big printing press, rent or buy a building, hire staff, etc. Now, all you need is a personal computer.

These game changers require you to think in new ways about what your biggest opportunities are in the future.

As far as talent goes, it seems that we're born or hard-wired with certain talents or gifts. There are two main ways you can figure out what these talents are for you: from the inside and the outside. From the inside, you might ask yourself "What am I really great at, and enjoy doing? What are things I can do for hours and just get lost in the task?" From the outside, you can take written tests, ask others what they think your talents are, etc.

After you identify your talents, next you have to identify an opportunity in the world where your talent can be used. The idea of "do what you love and the money will follow" can be damaging if you believe in it too much. Usually when you do this, you wind up chasing money your whole life, because there's usually not an automatic connection between doing what you love and turning it into income. Instead, take some time to look out in the world and identify the areas that are growing financially and are most likely to continue to grow over the next 20 years. Then connect your talent to these high growth areas.

Next, you need to develop your talents and gifts into strengths. You'll do this by growing your talent, ideally toward a high-growth opportunity. Your strength gets stronger, and the opportunity grows bigger, and so your success accelerates. The idea here isn't to just "randomly" develop yourself in whatever direction you want - you're going to do it in the direction of opportunity.

A critical part of this process is to get Master External Feedback. This is important because none of us have an objective view of our strengths and weaknesses, and we're not good at evaluating our own potential. But people who are "masters" - who are further down the road than we are - see us much more objectively. This is incredibly valuable, because they can point out to us what the next step in our evolution should be. So it's vitally important we have mentors who can see the next level for us. Also, we all naturally want to hide our weaknesses and things we're not good at. Get over it. Get high quality mentors and follow their advice.

Remember: Your talent may feel very easy to you. It may feel like you're "cheating" to claim that this is an actual talent. For example, some people are great at figuring out their relationship issues. They do it naturally, it's effortless, and people come to them for this kind of help. That is one of their talents.

Exercises:

1) Ask yourself, "What am I good at? What pulls me into engagement in the world? What active task so engages me that I can work on it for hours, relatively effortlessly, where time disappears?"

2) Ask yourself, "What do people ask me for help with?"

3) Ask 10 other people who know you, what they believe your gifts or talents are. You can write an email that says, "Dear John, I've got a question for you. Right now I'm in a program learning how to develop myself. And one of the exercises is for me to ask people who are close to me what my gifts and talents are. Would you tell me what you think my gifts and talents are?"